

Patterns in Play — Module 07: Communication — Think About It

Part A: Family Discussion Questions

1. Why is teamwork harder than playing alone? (You have to communicate your plans to another agent!).
2. How do sports teams communicate during a game? (Signals, shouts, eye contact, practiced plays).
3. What happens when teammates do not communicate? (Confusion, collisions, lost opportunities).
4. Why is telling a story a powerful form of communication? (It transfers a whole world from one brain to another).
5. How do you let someone know you want to play with them? (Ask! Invite! Or just start playing nearby).
6. What is the difference between cooperating and competing?
7. Why is it hard to play pretend with someone who imagines a different story? (Your models need to align!).
8. How can you tell if a teammate needs help? (Reading their signals — face, voice, body).
9. What makes a good captain or team leader? (Clear communication, fairness, encouragement).
10. Can you play a game entirely in silence? What would you have to do differently?

Part B: Hands-On Activities and Reflection

1. Build something together (a puzzle, a Lego set, a fort) but you can only communicate through gestures — no talking! How hard is it? What strategies helped?
2. Tell a "Chain Story": One person says a sentence, then the next person continues. Go around three times. How does the story develop when multiple agents contribute?
3. Play "Back-to-Back Drawing": Sit back-to-back. One person describes a shape they drew. The other draws what they hear. Compare results — how accurate was the communication?

4. Do a relay race with instructions: Each person runs to a station, reads a task (do 5 jumping jacks, say a tongue twister), completes it, then tags the next person.
Communication under pressure!
5. Create a "Secret Code" as a family. Assign symbols to common words. Write a message in code and have someone decode it. You built a shared communication system!
6. Play a cooperative game (like Forbidden Island or Pandemic). Discuss: How did communication help or hurt your team's success?
7. Practice "Compliment Catch": Toss a ball. Whoever catches it must say something kind about the person who threw it. Positive communication builds strong teams.
8. Play "Two Truths and a Lie": Each person tells three things — two true, one false. Can the family spot the lie? This game tests how well you read others' communication.
9. Design a team cheer or family handshake together. Practice until everyone has it down. Shared rituals build communication bonds.
10. After play today, hold a "Team Debrief": What went well? What was hard? How could we communicate better next time? Great teams always review their communication.